

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	Meditation: the nature, purpose and significance of meditation in Buddhism; the different types of meditation: samatha (concentration), metta bhavana (loving kindness) and vipassana (insight); meditative practices, including mindfulness breathing and zazen, divergent understanding of the nature and importance of visualisation of the Buddha and Bodhisattvas, including Amitāyus Meditation Sutra; how the different practices are used by Mahayana and Theravada Buddhists and the benefits from their use.
2.2	Chanting: the nature, purpose and role of chanting in Buddhism as a devotional practice and to gain mental concentration, including Dhammapada 1–2, confidence and joy. The divergent understandings of the importance of chanting in Buddhist life today: Theravada Buddhism, including Tiratana Buddhism, with reference to Dhammapada 190, and Mahayana Buddhism, including Nam Myoho Renge Kyo.
2.3	Mantra recitation: divergent understandings of the nature, purpose, role and importance of mantra recitation with reference to Theravada Buddhism, including Namo Buddhaya ("Homage to the Buddha"), and Mahayana Buddhism; the nature and purpose of using sacred syllables, devotional articles, offerings and mala beads, and why they are used in different schools of Buddhism.
2.4	Features of Buddhist places of worship: the divergent nature, history and design of Buddhist places of worship, including temples, gompas, viharas and shrines in Theravada, Mahayana and Triratna Buddhism; how and why the places of worship are used, including reference to the shrine room, shrine facing east, and the library, showing the importance of learning, with reference to the Kimsila Sutta.
2.5	How and why objects of devotion are used within different Buddhist places of worship, buddharupas, including reference to Vakkali Sutta, shrine, Bodhi tree; divergent understandings of why devotional objects are important in Buddhism today.
2.6*	Puja: the nature and purpose of puja in the vihara and the home, including reference to Mangala Sutta; examples of the different types; when each type might be used and why; the importance of having different types of worship and their use in different Buddhist contexts.
2.7	Death and mourning rituals and ceremonies: the divergent celebration and significance of the ceremonies in Buddhist communities and to Buddhists; the distinct significance of the rituals associated with death and mourning in Theravada communities and in Japan and Tibet, with reference to the Tibetan Book of the Dead.
2.8	Festivals and retreats: the divergent nature, history, purpose and importance of festivals and retreats in Buddhism; divergent understandings of the origins, meaning and features of celebration of specific festivals and retreats, including Wesak, Vassa/Rain Retreat and Kathina, with reference to the Anapanasati Sutta, and Uposatha days in Theravada Buddhism; Hanamatsuri and Obon (Japanese), Parinibbana Day in Mahayana Buddhism, and Lama Tsong Khapa Day in Tibet.

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Hinduism as a lived religion in the United Kingdom and throughout the world.

There are two sections: Beliefs and Teachings; Practices.

Students will be expected to study Hinduism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian.

Students should compare and contrast two areas of belief and practice within Christianity and Hinduism:

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.5)*
- The practice and significance of worship (2.4)*.

Students should recognise that Hinduism is one of the many religious traditions in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Islam, Judaism and Sikhism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content. Students should also recognise that within Hinduism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Hinduism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Shaivism and Vaishnavism.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs and practices to Hindus today should be explored throughout the two sections.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The nature of Brahman: the nature of Brahman as spirit, ultimate reality or absolute truth; how the characteristics of Brahman are shown in Hindu scriptures, including Katha Upanishad 2.2.6–8.
1.2	The nature and importance of understanding Brahman as Nirguna Brahman and Saguna Brahman: how Nirguna Brahman and Saguna Brahman are shown in Hindu scripture, for example Nirguna (Taittiriya Upanishad 2.7.1–2) and Saguna (Rig Veda 1.154.1–2); the nature and importance of Vaikuntha (spiritual worlds); divergent ways in which belief in each may be expressed in the life of Hindus today.
1.3	Three aspects of the divine: Brahman, Antaryami and Bhagavan; the nature and significance of the divine as Brahman (everywhere and non-personal), Antaryami (within the heart) and Bhagavan (beyond, as a personal loving God); how the three aspects are shown in Hindu scriptures, including Mundaka Upanishad 2.1; why belief in the three aspects of the divine are important in Hindu life and for religious pluralism today.
1.4	Manifestations of the Divine: the nature and importance of how the deities are shown in Hindu scriptures; avatars and murti; the nature and role of male deities: divergent understandings of the importance of Vishnu (including Rig Veda 1.22) and Shiva; the nature and role of the female force, Shakti, including Parvati and Lakshmi.
1.5*	The nature of the individual and life within Hinduism: the nature and importance of the atman (eternal self), karma, the cycle of samsara, moksha; divergent Hindu understandings of the nature of the individual and life, including interpretations of Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 4.4; why beliefs about the atman, karma, samsara and moksha are important for Hindus today.
1.6	The purpose of human life for Hindus: the nature and significance of the four aims of life (Purusharthas) – dharma, artha, kama and moksha; the nature and significance of anatana dharma (eternal law), including Bhagavad Gita 3.35; the nature and significance of varnashrama dharma (duties according to materialistic situation in life).
1.7	Hindu responses to suffering, knowledge and ignorance: Hindu teachings about suffering, knowledge and ignorance, such as ahimsa, respect, empathy, mind/sense control, humility, and love, including Mahabharata 5.39; divergent Hindu understandings as to why there is suffering, knowledge and ignorance for Hindus today.
1.8	Hindu cosmology: the nature of the Hindu cosmology as shown in Hindu scriptures, including Rig Veda 10.129; the nature and importance of the cycle of four ages (yugas), including descriptions of the Kali Yuga in the Mahabharata, many worlds and their diverse inhabitants; the nature and divergent understandings of the importance of the concepts of prakriti (matter/nature), tri-guna (three qualities) and maya (illusion).